
“Those who brought war ...
deserve all the curses ... a
people can pour out.”

WILLIAM T. SHERMAN, ATLANTA, 1864

Having just met the redoubtable William Tecumseh Sherman in March, 1865, Colonel Theodore Lyman of Massachusetts wrote to his wife, “All his features express determination, particularly the mouth, which is wide and straight, with lips that shut tightly together. He is a very homely man, with a regular nest of wrinkles in his face, which play and twist as he eagerly talks on each subject; but his expression is pleasant and kindly. But he believes in hard war.”

Perhaps that was deliberately understated. “War is cruelty and you cannot refine it,” Sherman himself had once stated. He had addressed those scathing words to Confederate general, John Bell Hood, who had protested against Sherman’s treatment of Atlanta’s civilians. “You might as well appeal against a thunderstorm as against these terrible hardships of war,” he went on. “They are inevitable, and the only way that the people of Atlanta can hope once more to live in peace and quiet at home is to stop the war, which can alone be done by admitting that it began in error and is perpetuated in pride.”

The man who could declare, “Let us destroy Atlanta and make it a desolation,” might have been born a warrior. Perhaps that’s what his father had hoped for when he named his third son after the famous Shawnee chief, Tecumseh. “William” was added at his baptism, and for most of his life he was affectionately known as “Cump.” But if he was a born a warrior, it was of the most unusual kind. The tall, lanky youth, who graduated from West Point widely respected for his brilliance, proved to be restless in the army. So